

Snakes in Paradise: Problems in the Ideal Life

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And this by the way satisfies a longing for the supernatural//
transcendental//, for in believing that they see the “limits of
human understanding” of course they believe they can see
beyond them.

Wittgenstein, *Big Typescript*

but the secret of speculative philosophy is theology.

L. Feuerbach, *Theses for the Reform of Philosophy*
(*Anthropologische Materialismus*, vol. 1., p. 82)

God as God—as an intellectual or abstracted being, that is, a
nonhuman, nonsensuous being that is an object only of reason or
intelligence and is accessible only to them—is nothing but the
essence of reason itself.

L. Feuerbach, *Principles of the Philosophy of the
Future*, Sec 6.

I think of the presence and of the habits of mortals in this so
fluid stream, and reflect that I was one among them, striving to
see all things just as I see them at this very moment. I then
placed Wisdom in the eternal station which now is ours. But
from here all is unrecognizable. Truth is before us, and we no
longer understand anything at all.

P. Valery, *Eupalinus or the Architect*

Bertrand Russell had a low opinion of Aristotle’s *Nicomachean
Ethics*:

The book, [he says,] appeals to the respectable middle-aged, and
has been used by them, especially since the seventeenth century,
to repress the ardours and enthusiasms of the young. But to a
man with any depth of feeling it is likely to be repulsive. (1947/
1961, 185)

and on the next page:

Aristotle's opinions on moral questions are *always* such as were *conventional* in his day.

Yet even Russell wilts before Aristotle's claim that the human good—the happiest or most successful human life—is a full lifetime spent in as much *contemplation* (*theoria*) as is ever possible given our human nature. Here, Russell admits, we come “to the only doctrine in the book which is not mere common sense”!

And we too immediately want to ask: what is this ‘contemplation’? How can it be supposed so valuable? Why should the best human life be one focused on a single activity? And why should it be the same activity for everyone? How *could* such an apparently—and, for Russell, overly—sensible philosopher as Aristotle make such a claim?

To understand how he could, and indeed what exactly it is that he *is* doing, we need first to expose two ‘ambiguities’ in his *project* of specifying the best, or happiest, life. We need to distinguish between defective and perfect circumstances and then between two ways of conceiving of the latter.

PART 1

1. The First Ambiguity: Two Ways of Living Perfectly (Lives of Perfect People and Perfect Lives)

Aristotle's central question in the *Nicomachean Ethics* (*NE*) is that of the human good, the end of rational choice and action (1.2.1094b24-5). This is quickly identified “by name” as *eudaimonia*—as living well (*euzoia*) and acting well (*eupraxia*). The nominal identification is relatively uncontroversial: what is controversial is what constitutes *eudaimonia* (1.4.1095a14-22).

So Aristotle's target at least seems obvious, however controversial its answer may be. Yet actually the target itself needs clarification—in several ways. Aristotle wants to know what *living well* is. But is he looking to specify the very best *living*, that is, life-activity, or the very best *life*—how humans would best live over an entire human lifetime? Shelve this for a moment. There is a further unclarity in asking how humans would best live. Are we asking:

how human beings best live *whatever the circumstances* that arise to face them in life,

or asking

how human beings best live given *ideal circumstances*—the optimal conditions for a human, those that legislators and politicians should try and achieve for their citizens?

The answer to the first is at least this: that, as rational agents, it is *one* of our targets or ideals to *live perfectly*, in the sense of doing what is best *given* the conditions and circumstances that happen to confront us in our lives, *whatever* these turn out to be. To achieve this, we need to be practically wise (*phronimoi*)—good, or perfect, *people*, with all the human excellences, all the correct values. Only so shall we both be able to discern and be disposed to do what is best whatever the circumstances of our lives, and so in this sense live the best, or most perfect, lives possible in our circumstances—lives of which we can be proud and whose actions we do not regret: for they were what the circumstances called for. But, of course, these, whether or not of our own making, may be nonideal, defective, even tragic: thus we may have to deal with incapacitating illness, our own or that of others, or to abandon our careers to fight in a just war or to protest an unjust one. Such defects may lie either in ourselves or in our environment.¹

Now, if living perfectly in this sense is our question, our focus will naturally be on what sort of people we should be, on what are the correct human values, and also on more casuistical, or immediately practical, questions of how best to live in *this* case or given *these particular* circumstances.

Such cases and circumstances may be ones we correctly wish had not arisen in the first place. They are impeding and interfering factors. But what exactly do they impede? Our *living perfectly* in another sense. Here we arrive at a second target and ideal. We want not just to live perfectly in the first sense but to live perfectly in the sense of enjoying lives properly lived in as perfect circumstances as is ever possible for a human (or at least at our general historical juncture). Just as you might seek to know how some plant lives when given optimal internal and external conditions—it is not diseased, and is planted in a soil and climate most suited to it—taking this to provide the norm or measure for its success.² If living perfectly in this sense is our question, then our concern is, I shall say, with the *Utopian* ideal.

We have put this distinction between two ideals of a perfect life in terms of different *senses* of “living perfectly,” as answers to two different questions. But we can equally put it in terms of when such talk *requires qualification*. Thus we could say: it is misleading, indeed false, to talk of living perfectly and totally admirably, but under defective circumstances and trying conditions, as “perfect living” *tout simple, haplos*, that is, without qualification. What is true is that it was living perfectly *given those circumstances*. The qualification is needed. For it is false that this is the *pin-up* of how human life should go; it is

the pin-up only of how human living should go *in such circumstances and situations*. The Utopian ideal, by contrast, is that of living perfectly *sans phrase*.³

But either way, the point is that, as rational agents, we have these two concerns: (1) to live perfectly in correctly realizing correct values whatever the situation—whether this is qualified or not; (2) to live perfectly without qualification, to live as well as a human ever can.

Elsewhere I have argued that it is the Utopian ideal that is Aristotle's main question in the *NE* (Lawrence 1993). (i) The best human life is a matter of the best human living, over a full human lifetime. (ii) And the best human living is a matter of doing what it is for a human as such to do, and doing it well—and (iii) this is a matter of doing human life-activity, or life-activities, in accord with the excellence(s) proper to them (1.7.1097b22-98a20). (iv) If one of the excellences is superior—more final—to the rest, then the activity of which that is the proper excellence will, done well, constitute *perfect eudaimonia* (1.7.1098a17-18, cf. 1.8.1099a29-31, 7.13.1153b10-11, 10.5.1176a26-7). As Aristotle says in 10.7.1177a12-13:

If *eudaimonia* is an activity in accord with excellence, then it is reasonable (*eulogon*) that it is in accord with the most valuable [excellence] (*kratiste*); and this is that of the best part [of soul].

Aristotle here goes on to claim that there is a superior part of the human soul, *nous* (cf. 6.12.1143b33-35, 6.13.1145a6-11), and that its excellence, theoretical wisdom (*sophia*), is more final than the other excellences (*ibid.*, cf. 1.7.1098a17-18). And so its activity, which is contemplative, is, if well done, a life of perfect happiness (10.7.1177a17, cf. b24). He concedes that such a perfect life is more than a human can actually achieve: as a human, even under the most favorable circumstances, there will inevitably be needs and demands—physical, emotional, and social—for other life-activities. Nonetheless we should strive to approximate such a life, and so live a life whose circumstances leave us *free* to engage in as much of the single best life activity as is ever humanly possible. And politically we should aim to make such lives available.

Let us note two points. First, Aristotle accepts an activity-to-life value transfer principle. That is, the value of a *life* is a function of the value of the life-activity/-ies that compose it: the best life is made of the best activities, and if one activity is better than others, then of that one alone. Aristotle apparently takes this as self-evident, as a formal principle of reason (1.7.1098a18-20, 10.7.1177b24-6, cf. 1.8.1099a30 etc.).

Second—and this is the main point of this section—while Aristotle says the best human life is the one with the maximum amount of contemplation over a complete natural lifetime, he

also allows that a life consisting entirely in ethical and political activity well done is (or can be) a successful life. But it is *eudaimonia* only in a secondary degree (*deuteros*). Now as I interpret him the point of difference between these two lives is *not* one between different values different people might put on different human activities—different activities to which they might *devote* their lives. On the contrary, it is the same people in both cases: they are both *phronimoi*, practically wise. As such they know the goods and the bads of human life and their relative worth; they are good at deliberating and at seeking advice when the going gets tough. They live *wisely*. The difference between them lies in the opportunities and circumstances of their lives. Neither has anything to regret in *doing* what they do in their lives; but the one who has to live the ethico-political life will—and should—regret *that* their circumstances did not leave them *free* to engage in the most valuable activity of all, that is, in contemplation.

So interpreted, Aristotle is not, in *NE* 10, advocating a *value monism*. He is not claiming that the best life is a matter of holding that only a single activity, the best, is of value. Nor is he advocating one particular value monism over another. He is not adjudicating a competition whose competitors are two ways of living, each *devoted* to different values—one taking political power as the only, or supreme, value, and the other taking contemplation to be so. He is, I admit, concerned with such an ‘Academic/ Isocratean competition’, but he offers a typically Aristotelian resolution (*lusis*). Both sides have truth on their side, but both fail to distinguish between value and activity, and their opposition can now be resolved: a human must be devoted to both values—indeed to all correct values—and in some circumstances one sort of living or life will be the best and what is called for, and in another set the other. But this resolution brings into focus a further question, about which circumstances are ideal for humans—ones that call for the exercise of which of the values (or both)? This ‘new’ question is Aristotle’s primary concern: what is it to live perfectly in our second, unqualified, Utopian, sense? And *this* he answers with a monism, but it is one of *activity*, not of *value*: under optimal human conditions, there is a single best *life activity*. And if we now apply the first point—the activity-to-life value transfer principle—we end up with a *life monism*, a claim that the perfect life consists in a full lifetime whose circumstances are such that it is always best to do the unqualifiedly best life-activity. This is a regulative ideal. Whether we can *ever* do perfectly this best, god-like, activity is something Aristotle is perhaps cautious about. But that we cannot do it *all the time*—even all our short lifetimes—is obvious. The life-monism is expressly conceded to be an *ideal*: we cannot fully attain it and can only approximate it, although that is indeed what we should do (10.7.1177b26ff).⁴

To conclude. The primary target of Aristotle's investigation is living a perfect life *haplos*, that is, in the Utopian sense.

2. Problems for Aristotle's Utopian Answer of Activity Monism and Life Monism

Aristotle is, I think, correct to distinguish these two rational targets or ideals within "living perfectly" and correct to pose and pursue the Utopian *question*. Even for the good, life can go better and worse—and in ways that humans can, individually and socially, do something about. This is a fact of very real importance. Identifying circumstances as nonideal depends on a conception of ideal ones. If one wants to know what the Carpenter or the Adder Does—what Carpentering or Adding are—you do not mention mistakes: there are infinite ways of going wrong, that do not belong in an account (or a manual) of what it is to Carpent or Add.⁵ Perhaps it is also part of an art to know what to do in some nonideal situations—how best to recover from certain mistakes (internal defects in the artist), or treat shortcomings in the material (external defects) (cf. *Rep.* 2.360E7-361A2; et al.). Even so the ideal specification is the focus. And as with the norms of arts, so too with the accounts of living things. Aristotle's question is, I think, correct. His answer, however, is another matter entirely. It faces real problems—and is, I believe, hijacked by *the sublime*—by a rationalist metaphysics.

Now there are allegedly quite general problems with any form of Utopianism, to the effect that, for instance, it presupposes a fixity about human nature that is naive and a-historical (a worry from Herder and Nietzsche through to Berlin, Nozick, and Williams).⁶ More pertinently there are problems both in the general *form* of Aristotle's answer—in its monisms of activity and life—and in its *specific content*, that is, in his own particular monist candidate for best life-activity, contemplation (*theoria*).

Activity monism, while not as absurd as value monism, still seems absurd. (i) Surely, just as there are many things we, as human beings, should *value*, similarly, even in perfect or ideal circumstances, there are many activities we want, or should want, the opportunity to engage in and enjoy over the course of our lives, not just one. Certainly some activities are better and more worthwhile than others—but how can we suppose that just a single activity is better than all the rest?—that, say, doing research in physics is more worthwhile than composing music? Moreover much human activity is complementary—those of an orchestra or a surgical team or a construction site. (ii) And even if there were a single best activity in each person's case, why would it be the same? This would be to ignore differences of talent and taste and to suppose a uniformity that is foreign to human nature, freedom of choice, and capacity for

development (cf. *Rep.* 2.370A-B). (iii) Again, the principle that takes us from activity monism to life monism also seems bizarre. (a) It seems a recipe for an impoverished life—to make it monomaniac where it should be well rounded.⁷ It would be strange to suppose that, special circumstances apart, a life spent researching in physics is better than such a life when it also includes music. (b) Moreover we are creatures who become bored, jaded, burned out, find things monotonous—and, conversely, find change, accompanied as it often is by the elements of novelty and risk, to be pleasant, refreshing, stimulating, exhilarating. We value a certain variety for its own sake—it is, we say, ‘the spice of life’. Admittedly, we are equally creatures capable of preoccupation and absorption in a certain activity—even obsession. We value a certain application and concentration and criticize mere dilettantism and light-minded ‘change for change’s sake’. So both change and stability can be well and badly handled.⁸ But that in general we find life rich and value a certain amount of change and variety reflect the facts that many human activities are worthy of our attention and that a certain variety suits us, being the creatures we are.

So *prima facie* it is puzzling to suppose (i) there might be a single best activity, that (ii) it might be the same one for all, and that (iii) the perfect life would consist entirely of that activity.

Several things may be said in reply. Most pertinent is the point that the notion of the single best activity is as yet not cashed out. The apparent absurdity of this singularity depends in the first instance on the *degree of specificity* of the proposed monist candidate. Thus if the candidate activity were, say, Marx’s, or Mill’s, notion of *self-development*, the relative formality and generality of this—the fact that it encompasses a great, and historically changing, variety of more specific activities—goes some way to defuse our initial absurdities. It is compatible with a realistic, and historically sensitive, variety both between people and within lives.

How then does Aristotle’s own candidate—contemplation—fare?

In the Function Argument, in *NE* 1.7, Aristotle is concerned with activities at a very general level—with different basic ways of being alive. And what is distinctive about the human way of being alive is, roughly, our capacity for reason-involving activity very broadly construed—so that it includes our emotional lives (*NE* 1.7.1098a3-4; cf. Lawrence 2001, 459). And this seems plausible: what centrally matters in life are these activities, done well. Without these—and left only as a mere vegetable or dumb beast or sunk in dreamless sleep—our life doesn’t seem worth continuing (cf. Lawrence 2001, 461–2). So rational activity, well done, is the focal life-activity for humans. But clearly an undifferentiated notion of such rational activity

well done cannot itself figure as the specification of the perfect life *sans phrase*—because of the point about acting well in defective circumstances. We need to go further. And the way Aristotle does so is by introducing a second level of focality, one *within* these rational activities and their correlative excellences. (cf. Lawrence 1997, 74–5). The fault line he draws is between practical and theoretical reason and their respective excellences and activities.⁹ Part at least of the *point* and *value* of the activities of practical reason is, he suggests, to secure the conditions for the activity of theoretical reason, contemplation. And it is a life of the latter that, done well, is—or would be—perfect happiness. Thus contemplation is supposed itself to be a basic life activity, a basic way of being alive—indeed the one and only way in which god is alive; and, at least for humans, it also seems to cover a wide-ish range of intellectual subjects—natural science, mathematics, and first philosophy or theology (cf. *Meta* E.1.1026a6–22).

Now this second level of focality introduces a less plausible monist ideal—one that immediately seems overly intellectualist. Two factors at least seem to be influencing Aristotle at this point.

First, in giving priority to the Life of the Mind, Aristotle explicitly wishes to align himself with a certain tradition of the *sophoi*—he refers us to Thales, Pythagoras, Anaxagoras, and others (*NE* 6.7.1141b3–8; *Protrep.* frg 11W, Ross). These *sophoi* stand opposed to worldly ideas of happiness and success—they do not seek human goods, nor what is advantageous to themselves (1141b3–8):

Anaxagoras seems to have supposed that the happy person was not the rich nor the powerful, when he said that he would not be surprised if [the happy man] were to appear ridiculous to the many: for they judge by external things, having eyes only for these. (*NE* 10.8.1179a13–16; *EE* 1.4.1215b6–14)

Instead, the point and worth of human life is, for Anaxagoras, rather

“To contemplate whatever pertains to the heavens and to the stars and the moon and the sun in the heavens,” as though everything else was of no worth. (*Protrep.* frg 11W; *EE* 1.5.1216a10–16; cf. Plato, *Timaeus* 47Aff)

—a kind of half-Kant. But why on earth spend one’s life studying things that in their content have no bearing whatsoever on human affairs and human happiness—on stuff that is really useless (*achresta*)? Aristotle addresses the question in *NE* 6.12, pointing out that something, like study, can *constitute* human happiness, even though it is not itself concerned with it and so is useless. And it is indeed a

remarkable fact about humans, as Aristotle also notes in *Meta. A.1*, that they are capable of wonder and wish to understand things that are “*peritta kai thaumasta kai chalepa kai daimonia*” (*NE* 1141b6-7) for their own sake and not simply for any practical use they may have.

The main opposition in this tradition is to worldly success, to giving a priority to external goods (cf. *Pol.* 7.1.1323a25-7, 34-8, b40-24a2; Lawrence 1997, 51). Seen in this light, the relative narrowness of the intellectual ideal is something that could be modified while keeping to the spirit of the contrast.¹⁰

A second influence is the attraction of the very conception of practical reason that encourages Aristotle to draw the fault line where he does. So viewed, practical reason has as its proper end to determine what is best and wisest in order to bring it about: and this is living well, or living perfectly, not only in the sense of what is best in the circumstances, but also in the Utopian sense. So part of practical reason’s aim is to bring about circumstances that are perfect in that they give the agent the leisure or free time to engage in the very best activity humans are capable of. So it aims to determine and bring about *eudaimonia*, and in so doing it looks beyond itself and its own operations and activities. But how can an activity be itself fully or finally constitutive of happiness, or living well, if it is an activity that is itself directed at securing *that*— if it has as an end something other and beyond itself? As Aristotle says,

the activity of the politician is un-leisurely and acting politically concerns itself with power and status or at least with *eudaimonia* for the agent and his citizens, being *different* from *politike* and which we seek clearly as being *different*. (*NE* 10.7.1177b12-15)

So practical reason has a productive aspect and as such its activities seem *relatively un-final*. Admittedly its operations and activities *can* themselves constitute living well, for they may be what constitutes living well and wisely *in the circumstances*. But they can do so only to a secondary or qualified degree—imperfectly. The circumstances in which such activity is best are defective ones: if they were perfect, we would already be enjoying that happiness that practical activity seeks to secure for us. So part of its point and value lies in its helping to bring about the enjoyment of free time, or prevent impediments to that—whether for the agent or for others. And part of the worth of our practical activity depends on there being such seriously good activity to fill free time: if all we were up to were idle amusements, natural Disney-landers, then part of what makes humans worth bothering about, worth all the pain and fuss, would disappear. So the activities of *politike* and *phronesis* (practical reason on a public and a private scale) are concerned

with securing human happiness in such a way that they themselves cannot unqualifiedly or perfectly constitute it (they are to an extent second order projects). Their activities are humanly *useful*—whereas it now appears that the perfect activity not only can be, but *must* be, *useless*, on pain of pointing to some further good outside itself. The perfect activity is thus “*autoteles*”: self-ended. And our need for practical activity—the fact that this can be what is best and wisest for us to engage in—reveals a defect, something less than perfect, in the human situation.

Again Aristotle seems onto something—a contrast between free time, with its activities of freedom and self-development, and the apparently business-like nature of ethical and political activity as requirements of the human situation—the realm of freedom beyond the realm of necessity.¹¹ What is problematic may seem only an unnecessarily restricted view of the activities of free time.

There is something to this. But it is much more problematic than the above suggests: in the demoting of practical reason and in its ‘productive’ subservience to theoretical reason, too much of what is central to human life is given up—something not to be restored perhaps until the practical Christian god replaces the Aristotelian theoretic god, and Kant comes along. Moreover Aristotle seems to forget that for us contemplation is (or should be) a chosen action in a sense it never is for god, assessable in ways it never is for god.

But besides these two factors, there is an obvious third factor—what we may call Aristotle’s “metaphysical,” or supernatural views, about the essence and worth of intuitive intellect (*nous*) and its activity, which is contemplative (*theoretike*).

Nous, or theoretical intellect, is clearly something very special for Aristotle—it is likely to be “a different genus of soul” (*De An.* 2.2.413b24-7), and since it isn’t “bound up with matter” it is not studied by the *phusikos* (*Meta.* E.1.1026a5-6, 1025b32-3; *De Part. An.* 1.1.641b18ff, b33ff).¹² It is by far and away the most valuable and best part of soul in a human—it is divine or the most divine of things in us (10.7.1177a12-18, b6-1178a8). And its value lies in part in the supreme value of its objects (cf. *EE* 1.5.1216b19-20; *NE* 6.7.1141a18-22, a33-b8, 10.7.1177a19-21). And so “the activity of this in accord with its proper excellence (*sophia*) would be perfect *eudaimonia*.” The activity of *nous* is contemplation. This is an activity not merely as against a capacity (a *dunamis*), but in the strict sense of activity in contrast to process, *kinesis*. As such it is not any process of intellectual *inquiry*: for then its value would lie outside itself, in its product (cf. *NE* 1.1.1094a5-6, etc.)—and

it stands to reason (*eulogon*) that the passage of time [*diagoge*] is pleasanter for those who know than those who enquire. (10.7.1177a26-7)

This is all rather mysterious. Unsurprisingly really—given that contemplation is a divine activity and that itself in a rather special sense: it is god.¹³ But as Hardie (1968, 344) succinctly remarks: “knowing is not a way of passing the time”: so god is a grammatical mistake. Kraut (1989, 73) finds “contemplation” less mysterious: it is, he suggests

a process of reflection on a system of truths already discovered;

an activity that goes on whenever one brings certain truths to mind: it occurs not only when one silently reflects, but also when one lectures or writes about a certain subject...;

it is a matter of “consciously considering truths,” “a state of mind” that is “the activation of the understanding one has achieved....” But, like Hardie, I doubt whether there is any such single activity as Kraut here posits—although to be fair it raises issues about what the criteria for “an activity” are.

Aristotle is engaged in some sort of metaphysical enterprise; and it is this that I want to begin to understand better.

There are, it seems to me, several dimensions to Aristotle’s thought, which made it hard to track. First, there is a complex of what we may call “controlling thoughts” about perfection, principles that strike Aristotle as rationally self-evident (like the Best Activity/Best Life value transfer principle). These power both a secular version of the perfect human life and a supernatural or transcendental one. But it is the principles themselves that are, I believe, misleading.

Second, Aristotle’s philosophy is not simply one of construction by rational principles: argument to what is “*eulogon*” must be sensitive to what is “*kat’aisthesin*”—to the *thats* and more broadly to the *phainomena* and the *legomena*. Ordinary and reflective opinions about topics cannot be ignored: they constrain flights of pure reason (cf. *NE* 1.8.1098b9-12); more than that, they set the initial parameters of the topic. They represent our collective thinking about what the world around us is like. And they do so not as mere pre-theoretical data, but they already involve a conceptualization of the world that we are trying to account for and the range of views we find it natural to take. Aristotle lives in a world where perhaps the natural default is one that takes it as more alive than dead, and more alive the higher you look—the night sky looks to be full of regular, measured, ordered movement that speaks of rational intelligence (cf. *De Caelo* 2.12.292a14-22) and whose light seems an outward sign of their inner intelligence. This order seems so evident that another epoch, forced to retreat from the rational being of the ordered sky, will simply relocate it: if rationality is not in the stars as subjects, it is in them as the artifacts of a rational designer. All this suggests that the

world we are to account for is one that at least initially looks to be full of superior intelligences—(a) their order is so much more simply achieved than all the business we have to do to bring order to our lives, and (b) it lasts apparently forever, whereas the order of our lives, as of our gardens, is so very transient. No weeds in the night sky.

So what appears to us as Aristotle's metaphysics is not simply a product of top-down pure reason; but equally a matter of a bottom-up view of the world that is there to give an account of, a view that by our standards is supernaturally rich and already primed for "metaphysics."

3. The Second Ambiguity: Ordinary and Absolute Utopianism

3.1. *Two Ideals of P perfection*

The first disambiguation in understanding Aristotle's project of specifying the best human life was to distinguish between two senses of living perfectly—between life lived as well as it could be *given its circumstances* and life lived as well as it ever could be, *sans phrase*, that is, in optimal, or Utopian, circumstances. The second ambiguity in the project is one *within* the Utopian ideal. How are we to understand the unqualified or unconditioned claim of some *human* life that "this is the best, the perfect, the ideal, life: there couldn't be a better one"?¹⁴ On *one* understanding of the truth conditions of this claim—call it (P)—the relevant context and domain of assessment is that of the life of the human species, in the sense that the truth of (P) is unaffected by the manner of life of other species or substances, be they bestial or divine. If we add "human" to the claim (P), though grammatically a qualification, it will not be a "logical" one; it will neither change the claim nor imply that there is a further sense-ful question to be addressed, as to whether the perfect *human* life is the perfect life. The addition of "human" would simply be to avert misunderstanding—to make clear, if the context had not, that it is the perfect life of the human we are considering, and not that of some other organism, on the presumption that what counts as the best life is *species-specific*, as health is (cf. *NE* 6.7.1141a28-33). But on the *other* understanding, the context and domain of assessment is the cosmic, or absolute, one. Here the truth of (P) is affected by how the ideal or perfect species, or substance, lives—or would live if it existed. If (P) is true as it stands, this will be because the human life in question sufficiently instantiates, measures up to, or resembles this absolute ideal or norm. (It is not ruled out *ab initio* that Humankind is itself the perfect substance.) And here the addition of "human" to (P) would make it into an altogether different, qualified, claim and would imply that there *is* a still further question to be settled about whether the perfect, or best,

human life is the perfect life *sans phrase*—about whether ideal *human* circumstances are *absolutely* ideal ones. Moreover, in order to determine the best humanly achievable life, it can seem, we would need to know what the absolutely best life is. That provides the scale on which to measure and determine the best that humans can do and to settle whether the best human life is sufficiently like the absolutely best one to count as *eudaimonia* (the life of a god or perfect being).¹⁵

So there are two possible Utopian ideals—the ordinary, *species-specific*, or *species-contextual* ideal, and what following Moore (1903, ch. 6. init.), we can call the *absolute* ideal. The difference between these assessments of a life as unqualifiedly, or unconditionally, good consists in two different understandings of the range of qualifications or conditions that can count as impediments. Roughly, one does not, and the other does, take the condition of being human as itself a possible candidate for being an impediment.

On the *species-specific* understanding of the project to determine the best (human) life, not every circumstance of human life is up for assessment as a possibly defective, or detrimental, circumstance or limiting condition. The assessment presupposes a certain backdrop—certain general facts of human nature and the human environment that are not themselves up for evaluation. They are rather frame, or boundary, conditions—conditions that define or, more generally, demarcate the creature and its world whose best life it is we are seeking to specify, and without which we would be unable to determine in what the organism's good or bad consisted; for we would start to lose sight of the organism. It is only against this backdrop that other conditions can be evaluated as ones that mar or qualify *human* life.

For example, an *ordinary* view of our frame conditions would include our mortality and our various physical, emotional, social, and intellectual capacities and needs—such general facts as those Aristotle points to when he notes that humans by nature desire to find out or understand (*Meta.* A.1.980a1-2) that by nature they imitate and first learn this way, and that they have a natural sense of harmony and rhythm (*Poet* 4.1448b2-19, b20-2). It would also include certain facts of our environment, such as that we are subject to various dangers from the inorganic and the organic world and, again, that we are subject to historical contingency (e.g., are born before or after plague or AIDS; or the invention of the car, the saxophone, vaccination). If so, then the fact that, being human, we die is, unlike aspects of the manner or time of our individual deaths, not ordinarily intelligible as a defect, or bad, in the perfect life: it is not an occasion for qualification. That is, it is not a proper counter to a claim that someone had a life of perfect happiness *sans phrase* simply to object “*But they died.*” Similarly the facts that, being

human, we age and get physically and mentally tired, are, unlike aspects of the manner or time of an individual's aging or tiredness, not possible defects. Nor does the historical contingency that one lives before, or in, the age of the car count as a defect, at least not without some special setting or story. Nor again is the fact that human life is lived subject to certain general risks, of accident or disease, and that accruing a certain number of scratches, bruises, and colds is the norm. This is simply a fact of human life: it is not clear what it would be for it to be otherwise. However the realization of such risks, or some untimely realization, may mar an otherwise perfect life: "But they were struck down by lightening in their prime" is ordinarily an objection to the perfection of a human life in the way that "but they could have been struck at any time" ordinarily is not; "a tortoise fell on his head at ninety" probably isn't enough to cancel out a hitherto perfect life—unless perhaps intentionally dropped by one's spouse.¹⁶

The above is somewhat crude. What are boundary conditions and what not, and when a boundary condition can itself be brought in from the frame and appear as a qualification, or vice versa, are not simple matters (cf. Wittgenstein 1969). And it may be that "species"—at least if understood in terms of modern biology—is not quite the right concept, and we need something more like "form of life." But set these aside.

Now, implicit in this approach is a certain "descriptive contextual" conception of evaluation. Just as things are what they are, and have what point they do, in the context of human life generally—as a sentence has its sense in the context of a language—so also with value. What is the best, happiest, or most successful life for an X is determined by what it is to be alive as an X and the happenstance of the world—its climate, culture, and historical circumstance. Likewise, understanding what an emotion is, is not to be sought by ostending, or attending to, some peculiar inner feeling, or tone, but in its surround—what went on during, before, and after—so too with something's final value. An account of something's final value will consist in explaining its place and point in human life—in describing what, *given* the facts of human nature and our world, human life is like with it, and what it is like without it—as one might do with health, or what Socrates attempts to do for justice, in the *Republic*.¹⁷

Let us call this a species-contextual conception of evaluation. Very roughly:

SCE Just as a language needs a form of life, so something is good, or valuable, only in the context of the life of a species (of a form of life). Abstracted from this the thing is pointless—becomes a dead sign. It is its place in the context of the life of the species and its world that gives it life and

that both gives sense to the question “what’s the good of it?” and determines its answer.¹⁸

Within such a conception of evaluation, there is no obvious sense (1) to *global judgments*—to judgments that the world “itself” is a better, or worse, place for the existence of something, unless we mean by this that *we* are better, or worse, off by its existence, for we are better off by the existence of lots of things. (2) If so, then in particular it affords no obvious sense to such *inter-species evaluations* as that the life of the Human is better than that of the Banana Slug, that is, to the idea that there is a *scala naturae* of value.¹⁹ We can find sense in these sentences, but only as, say, extravagant expressions of how important some aspect of human life is to us (e.g., how distasteful it strikes us to leave a trail of slime). Yes, some life-activities are more central to us than others, and the loss of them more devastating for our humanity: for example, the loss of reason over the loss of sight. But this does not mean that the human is better than the eagle or that the latter is defective because it lacks reason. That is, there is no cosmic evaluation by which one species can be weighed against another, as having greater value in it, so that the world itself is better off with this species in it than that. This is not to say that there aren’t evaluations such that one should save an elephant rather than a weevil from drowning. But these are underpinned by facts stemming from the relative closeness of elephant life to human life, facts such as that elephants can *writhe*, where weevils only *wriggle*.²⁰ (3) Finally, it affords no obvious sense to claims of the *defective nature of humanity*, that the facts that we die, get thirsty, tired, angry, or bored and that our lives are constantly at some risk (and death an ever-present possibility) reveal defects in the condition of being human. The claim that death is an evil can be understood as a heartfelt expression of how much we enjoy life, of how much we are distressed at the passing of those we love, and of our terror at our own extinction.²¹

Matters are quite otherwise with the *absolute* understanding of the domain of assessment in the talk of the unqualifiedly best or perfect life. Here the absolutely unconditional good is construed as the absolutely perfect life, the life lived by the absolutely best substance. This version of an absolute approach deserves to be called *theological*, in the sense not of the study of the Christian god nor of religion, but of the study, or rational construction, of *the ideal or perfect substance*, that is of what constitutes unconditional goodness, perfection, or success, in the category of substance—a special, indeed the primary, branch of Ontology (cf. Lawrence 1997, 75).

We are to understand unqualified talk of the best thing, or the perfect life, as an *absolute* lack of qualification. Something is unconditionally good or perfect if, and only if, it is good—the

best—and is so, no matter what the condition or circumstance in which it is, or is placed; there is no condition in which it would not be good, and just as good in itself. And if it is good under any and every condition—if no condition can impede it—then in effect it is not “under” any, but rather there are no conditions or circumstances for it. This suggests that it is *context-free*, that it transcends, or “stands outside,” the world—or if not outside, then at its apex: it is not at all dependent on anything beyond itself.

Being thus independent of the world, the unconditional good must be *intrinsically good* in the sense of having value *entirely in itself, without reference to anything beyond itself*: if it is good even were the rest of the world not there, then there is nowhere else to locate that value: it has no ‘surround’. The world is merely a receptacle for it and the value it brings with it, like a purse for coins; and, like a purse, the world in which there is such a good is a world with more value in it than an empty one and, thus, a better one.

Now one could understand such intrinsic value in terms of some supposed simple property (a grammatical mistake that, for example, Moore makes). But the route I am interested in is one that seeks a theory of the perfections. The best thing won’t be defective in any possible way. And its exemplification of the perfections *constitutes* its being the unconditionally best thing—perfect in every way. That is, it is not simply a way of identifying the absolutely best thing but a theory of what it is for it to be the best. As I envisage it, this sort of absolute conception comprises a specificatory theory and a benchmark theory:

ACE *The Absolute Conception of Evaluation*

- I *A specificatory theory.* This may fall into two parts.
 - a *A formal account of perfections.* This delineates the conditions for something’s being absolutely unconditionally or intrinsically good—a theory of the perfections of substance *qua* substance.
 - b *A material account, which argues that such-and-such actually satisfies those conditions.*²²

This specificatory theory is complemented by

- II *A benchmark theory.* On this conception of evaluation the absolute good(s) functions as a benchmark, in the sense that it is by reference to this good that such value, or goodness, as anything else has is ultimately explained (and measured). If so, what is needed is a theory that specifies what relation(s) it is that other things have to the favored unconditional good and how this explains such value as they have.

We can flesh out this sort of conception by considering briefly some of the basic conditions something, O, would have to satisfy to be the absolutely unconditional good.

- B Clearly it must be *the very best thing*. Indeed it must be such that nothing could be better than it.

As such it is the measure of all other things. Measured against it, the ways in which all other (good) things are defective will show up—or in a positive vein, their degree of success will show up as a function of their approximation to the very best thing. So clearly there is no bar to inter-species evaluation.

It must also satisfy two other conditions, which I will call *independent* and *dependent primacy*. (Such conditions are ones on being a first principle, an *arche*, *Phys.* 1.5.188b27-8.)

- IP For O to be absolutely unconditionally good, O must not depend for its being good on anything else: O would be good, and just as good, even if the rest of the world weren't there. There need not be any other good things. (This is, or is very close, to a self-sufficiency claim.)

It is to that extent independent of, and detached from, other things. Otherwise its being good would be under some condition of the presence of some other (good) thing.

- DP For O to be absolutely unconditionally good, then if there are other good things, they must all depend on it: they would not be good, if O weren't there.

I see this as a need on the unconditional good's part. *If* there are other good things, then for there to be an unconditional good these other goods need in some way to depend on it. For if they were independent from it, then O would be defective in lacking some good(s), and their conjunction with O would comprise an even better good than O by itself.

This latter condition is close to another one, that of *explanatory primacy*:

- EP If O is absolutely unconditionally good, then the goodness of other good things is to be *explained* by reference to O.

This may be seen as a need on the part of other goods. The existence or goodness of other goods requires that there be some unconditionally good thing. (The relation of EP to DP needs further elaboration.)

These conditions are close to those of *EE* 1.8 (but this too is somewhat complex). There is, I think, a question about *how to combine* IP and DP/EP in something that is unconditionally

good—what rationale to give; and there is perhaps even a tension in doing so.²³ Aristotle, I suspect, sees in finality—sees in making the unconditional good “that for the sake of which, as end”—a way to provide a rationale, a plausible model, for such a combination:

- F For O to be the absolutely unconditional good, it must be that for the sake of which everything else is—the ultimate end. As such, it can exist without the things that are for its sake, and yet is the principle of being and order—organization—of everything under it: they depend on it.

Now such an absolute conception of evaluation presupposes—creates—a framework in which evaluation is not limited to the intra-species but is cosmic. On it, straightforward sense can be made of (1) of global judgments that something is absolutely good in the sense that “here and now the world is a better place because of this thing” (Korsgaard 1983, 169); and so also (2) of judgments of inter-species evaluations—moreover it promises a special cosmic, super-objective, grounding to ordinary intra-species judgments about the relative value of life-activities, such as that seeing or thinking are more valuable than digesting; and finally (3) it affords sense to judgments that the human condition is one that is itself defective in some or all respects.

3.2. *The Second ‘Ambiguity’ as a Version of the First*

This last is particularly striking as it brings out clearly that our second ‘ambiguity’ can equally be viewed, not as one *within* the Utopian notion of the perfect life, but as one between two ways of drawing our first distinction between perfect and imperfect circumstances. That is, there is an *ordinary* way of distinguishing defective and perfect conditions in human life and another where this distinction has been redrawn in a distinctly *metaphysical* way, whereby the condition of being human is itself intelligible as a defect. Thus *ordinarily* we talk of particular individual humans as being of limited intelligence or strength. Here their condition is a defect, their limit a limitation: for we measure the individual against the natural norm of the species, against the intelligence and strength an individual ought *qua* human to have. Equally *ordinarily* we may talk of the limits of human intelligence and human strength—that the Human cannot run as fast as the Cheetah nor calculate as fast as the Computer. This is a different kind of measuring, implying no defect; rather it simply articulates the boundaries of what the Human, as such, Does (can do).²⁴ This is the “mere boundary” use of “limit,” whereas the former is the “defect” use.

The absolute conception shifts the application of these two uses. It applies to the species as a whole what from the ordinary

perspective applies only to individuals within it. That is, what from the ordinary perspective were boundary conditions, the absolute conception aims to enable us to view as (potentially) defective ones: thus being a member of a species can itself appear as just another sort of defective, or limiting, condition an individual can suffer from—not simply a limit.²⁵ (Re Aristotle the suggestion would be that he re-applies teleology a level up—that teleology operates not only within species, but over species themselves.) The absolute conception tries to inflate to the maximum what we can conceive as the domain of assessment. One way of attempting this is by setting up a very special measure, an absolutely unconditional good, which is such, or so constructed, that the idea of looking over *its* walls is evidently conceptually impossible: for it is precisely designed to be the ideal and incapable of defect, so hedged around is it with superlatives and perfections. There is nothing to measure it by, nor could there be; but it is the measure of other things, the only thing whose limits are limits in the “mere boundary” sense—defined as it is by the perfect set of perfections. Here then is the home of the absolutely unconditionally good substance, which consists of the absolutely unconditionally good life, which consists of the absolutely unconditionally good life-activity. And just as in the ordinary perspective the species and their forms of life set the measures of success for their members, so here the ideal or perfect substance and its form of life does the same for the category of substance itself—and thus give us a measure for all the species (or substantial beings) and their forms of life (or forms of going on, if they are inanimate). This measure would determine both what constitutes success for them—what, given such limitations as they have, is their form of life at its best—and how successful or defective their form of life can be even at its best: that is, what their limitations are. So for example, it might determine that human beings, being what they are, should indeed value variety: for so doing helps them to live in a way that approximates as closely as they can to the absolutely ideal life (because, say, doing an admixture of other things relaxes them and helps them contemplate better). Yet their need thus to value variety—that it is indeed a good *in their case*—itself reveals, by the required qualification, a defect in the condition of being human, reveals that being of human nature is a qualification: for to be human is, in this respect, to be not self-sufficient for engaging in the best activity all the time.

4. Attractions of the Absolute Ideal

One of the attractions of the absolute conception, evident especially in its theological form, is that it purports to provide us with a benchmark, an “absolutely objective” cosmic scale, against which to evaluate the lives of different species including

our own, as also different types or modes of life within each. It would provide, in Nussbaum's words "species-independent criteria for ranking across lives" (1986, 374). That is, it promises an *external* evaluation of the human condition—one in no way *parti pris*. It avoids the presupposition both that human life must, at least at its best, be the ideal (as if Man were obviously the best substance in the universe) and that it must not be. Rather, abstracting away from, or transcending, our humanity, we try to specify the perfect substance and its life and then, in the light of this, establish our relative position in the scale of things. Human beings may turn out to be perfect substances, but if not, the respects in which our human condition even at its best is a limiting or defective one will be exposed, and explained. The absolute conception thus generates and grounds a "really" objective—a *super-objective*—specification of the best life.

Some form of absolute conception may appear not only attractive but unavoidable. Thus at the semantic level, it may seem that unqualified talk of the best life actually is an absolute usage or else that it in some way depends on or presupposes it. Or, in a more metaphysical vein it is argued, by Plato and Anselm, that all the many good things must share in the same explanatory grounding principle, and this requires and is provided by some (unique) absolutely unconditional good. Moreover the species-contextual conception may seem unable to account for the value of certain human life-activities, in particular those whose content is not at all, or not directly, concerned with humans and their welfare, yet which nevertheless humans set great store by, and (can) think of as, at least in part, constituting human happiness without thinking their value thereby resides in, or is explained by, their role in happiness (cf. *NE* 6.7.1141b3-9, 6.12). How then can these be valuable? If we want to preserve the ordinary view that these activities are "really" valuable "in themselves," and not merely contingently and subjectively, as a function of the interest humans happen to take in them, then it can seem that we are forced to suppose some human-transcendent perspective that endows them with value, to suppose that somehow it is their objects that endow them with value.²⁶

In any case, whether supposed not merely attractive, but required, an absolute conception seriously intends to establish that some activity, life, or species is cosmically better than others. This is quite distinct from heuristic projects designed to bring out what aspects of human life humans find, or ought to find, more important than others—as, for example, in the thought-experiment "Would you rather be a ... than a ...?" or "if you had the choice of being born or not, what would it take for you to choose being born?" (cf. *EE* 1.5.1215b20ff). In such a vein, one might argue not from the gods and how they live but—a

very different matter—from *popular conceptions* of the gods and their life. At this “meta-doxastic” level the interest is not in the truth of what people believe but in what their beliefs reveal about them and their aspirations. Such an argument is committed neither to the gods’ existence nor to any metaphysic of cosmic evaluation: it seeks simply to reveal the importance of something in human life by appeal to a popular vision of what constitutes a divinely good life, in much the same spirit as would an appeal to popular magazines about the lives of the rich and famous.

Now Aristotle certainly argues in this way at times, as in *Pol.* 8.5.1339b6-10.²⁷ And Aristotle is, I suspect, doing so in the “Argument from the Gods’ Activity” (*NE* 10.8.1178b7-23), where he argues that we *conceive* of the gods as supremely happy, and as alive and active (i.e., not asleep), and that given these conceptions it is absurd to suppose they engage in ethical actions, or in production, and so by elimination their life of supreme blessedness must be contemplative.²⁸ But even if correct as an interpretation of this argument, is this all that Aristotle commits himself to in the *Ethics*? Or even here is he entangled in serious metaphysics?

PART 2

5. Aristotle and the Theological Absolute Conception

It is sometimes supposed that Aristotle moved entirely away from a transcendent absolute conception to a ‘naturalistic’, or species-contextual one, and that signs to the contrary are simply his earlier Platonic views leaching through into his later ones.²⁹ After all, he claims, in criticism of Plato’s “singular explanatory grounding principle,” that the accounts of the goodness of different final goods are different; that is, there is not some single absolute good that provides a uniform universal ground of explanation (*NE* 1.6.1096b14-26; *EE* 1.8.). Furthermore the *NE* is explicitly concerned with the question of the *human* good and *human* happiness (see note 14). The focus seems solidly on the human, and at points Aristotle can seem at pains to avoid even his own metaphysical presuppositions.³⁰ So it may *seem* that Aristotle’s question, at least in the *Ethics*, is that of the unqualifiedly best human life in the species-contextual and not the absolute sense.

Against this is the presence of a systematic metaphysical, or theological, twist, drawing on an absolute conception, throughout his mature philosophy—in the *Metaphysics*, the *De Anima*, and the *NE* and *EE*. Without arguing this fully here, consider the following examples. (1) In *NE* 1.6. Aristotle says that good is said in as many ways as being. “The good,” he claims, “is said in

the category of substance (e.g., god or intellect) and in the category of quality (e.g. the excellences),..." etc. (1096a23ff; cf. *EE* 1.8.1217b30ff.). One may, following Ackrill (1972/1977, 23–4) take this to mean that god (or intellect) is what the good is in the category of substance as such, or else at least that god is an example of what a good substance is, in a sense in which one could then ask: "and is The Human, or The Aardvaark, good?" That is, certain things are good *qua* substances, *qua* being *the kind* of substance they are. If so, then this is no mere talk of intra-species good, and, from our ordinary perspective, is extremely puzzling. Aristotle must be presupposing some absolute perspective that provides a frame for these "cosmic evaluations," and where the perfect substance is being viewed as "the ultimate standard by which other things are judged." (2) *NE* 6.7. does indeed offer a *species-specific* view of practical wisdom or *politike*—as of medicine. Human practical wisdom concerns what is good or useful only in humans—and just as what is healthy is different in different creatures, so with their good generally. Just as there are species-specific medical arts, there are equally species-specific practical wisdoms (1141a20–26, 28–33). Nonetheless even here we find clear inter-species and cosmic evaluations, with implications about the defectiveness of the human condition. Aristotle remarks that it would be ridiculous to regard practical wisdom—wisdom about human goods and bads—as the most seriously good kind of knowledge unless man were the best thing in the kosmos (1141a20–22); but, while he may be the best of the animals, there are other things of "far more divine a nature." And it is these, the most prized, or valuable, things in their nature (*timiotata*), that are the concern of theoretical wisdom (1141a33–b2, cf. a18–20). So this is more seriously good than practical wisdom.³¹ (3) Again, in *Metaphysics* L.10.1075a11–25 Aristotle asks in what manner it is that the world ("the nature of the whole") contains ("has") the good, that is, the best thing—whether as something separate and alone by itself (like a penny in a pocket) or as the order of the whole world.

Or [he continues] is it in both ways, just as with an army? For there the good [*to eu*] is in the order and is the general, and rather more the latter (for it is not the case that he is/is good on account of the order, but that is/is good on account of him).

The perfect substance thus has goodness completely in itself—quite apart from the rest of nature, on which it does not depend (either for its existence or for its goodness): it is prized, by itself with respect to itself (*haute kath'hauten timia*: *NE* 10.8.1178b31; cf. *Pol.* 7.1.1323b23–26; *Meta.* L.7.1072b28). The world has this good in it as a receptacle, though it also has it in

another way, as the principle and source of the goodness of other things (i.e., IP and DP/EP).

The problem, one might argue, is that Aristotle didn't have a species-contextual conception of the sort I outlined earlier. He had a very different view of the facts of human life, of what goes into being human: that, for instance, humans can engage in an activity that is intelligible as going on after our bodily death and that is a divine activity. Thus an absolute conception seems already implicit in his view of the human species. This view is particularly evident in a famous passage from the *De Caelo* 2.12.292a22-b19:

For it is plausible for success [*to eu*] to belong without any action [*praxis*] to (A) that which is in the best condition; and to (B) the nearest to it through a little and a single [type of action], and to (C) those at a further distance through more—just as in the case of the body, (a) one is in a good condition without even exercising, (b) another after a little walking, but (c) for the next to need both running and wrestling and ...; and (d) to the next in turn not even however much it labors would this good indeed further belong, but some other (cf.292b17).... That is why we should think the action of the stars too to be like that of animals and of plants. For here too the actions of (C) the human are most numerous: for man is able to hit on many successes, so that he does many things, and for the sake of other things. But (A) for the one in the best condition there is no need of action; for it is itself the end.... (4) of other animals the actions are fewer; and of plants a small one and perhaps single: ... So then, (A) one thing has and partakes of the best, (B) another gets there directly through few things, (C) another through many, and (D) another doesn't even attempt it, but it is sufficient for it to come into a proximity with the ultimate [*to eschaton*: probably (A), rather than (C), cf.292b21]. For example, take health as the end: so (A) one thing is always healthy, (B) another by getting thinner, (C) another by running and [so] getting thinner, and another that also does something else for the sake of running, so that there are many processes; and (D) another is not able to get to being healthy, but to get only as far as to running, or to getting thinner, and it is one of these that is an end for them. For it is best for everything to attain most especially *the former* end [viz. the best], but, failing that, it is ever better the nearer it is to the best.³²

The idea here is that everything is organized around attaining the best. The topmost thing itself doesn't have to act *at all* to achieve the end—it *is* the end; then we get things that can indeed achieve the end, but only through taking action, action that, as we descend, is increasingly complex—both in amount, type, and distance (in means-end iteration); finally we get to

things that cannot themselves actually achieve the best by anything they can do—they can only approximate to it. Nonetheless even what these do is still to be viewed as organized around attaining the best, unattainable though it is by them. The human is here the hinge: it is the last thing whose complexity of action can actually enable it to realize something of the good, the very best sort of living. As we descend now, the complexity of action starts again to dwindle: we get to things that are able to do less and less—and so correspondingly *evince* less and less organization, an organization that represents the only way in which they partake in the best that they cannot realize. Finally, and very roughly, we come to something at the opposite extreme, something that is not the end, and that cannot do anything to attain it (earth?)—it too, like the very best, just does what it is, and can do no more—yet it is maximally indeterminate and potential, the negative. So as we descend the *scala naturae* we find an increasing complexity of actions that maximizes at the human—the last of things that can actually realize the best—and after that dwindles away again. The overall order is that of a mirrored cone, with humanity at the maximum circumference.

This allows that humans can, unlike other sublunary organisms, actually obtain the greatest good there is, although, unlike god and the stars, they have much to organize and do to achieve it to the limited degree they can. That they can indeed attain a share in it is born out by *EE* 1.7.1217a26-9:

for it is not the case that a horse is happy (*eudaimon*) nor a bird nor a fish nor any other of the things that are which do not, as the proverb has it, have a share (*metechei*) in something divine, but it is by some other sort of sharing (*metoche*) in good things that the one lives better and the other worse.³³

and the comparable passages in the *NE* (1.9.1099b32-1100a1, 10.8.1178b24-32).

6. Aristotle and the Specificatory Account

I suggested that it is natural for a specificatory account of the absolutely unconditional good to fall into two parts—a formal part that specifies the criteria or desiderata for such a good, and a material part that argues that some particular candidate(s) satisfies them.

The formal part is supposed not to be unconstrained. In *EE* 1.8., Aristotle criticizes the Platonists for beginning with things not already conceded to be goods and then trying to demonstrate from them what are already admitted to be goods. The procedure should, he says, rather be the reverse—

One should start from what are admitted to be goods, e.g. health, strength, and temperance, and prove that the fine is present even more in unchanging things. For all the former things are matters of order and rest/balance; if so [i.e., if they are good for these reasons], the latter will be more so; for these things [sc. order and rest] belong to the latter more. (*EE* 1.8.1218a21-4)

This suggests a three-stage method of (a) start by collecting things ordinarily regarded as good; (b) extract their general features—formal properties; (c) re-deploy these criteria to show they carry us beyond our ordinary starting points. Now the *NE* doesn't seem entirely to embrace this method (nor the *EE*). It seems to start rather *from* a formal notion of *the* human good as ultimate end of human chosen action. This is generally admitted to be, in name, "*eudaimonia*." But in 1.7.1097a25-b21, Aristotle appears to argue that this identification is correct on the grounds that the good that is being inquired into has the formal properties of unconditional finality and self-sufficiency; he doesn't extract these features from *eudaimonia*. Of course one could say that the fact that *eudaimonia*, admitted to be the good, satisfies these formal properties of the good ratifies the claim of these indeed to be formal properties of the good. But this isn't the apparent direction of Aristotle's argument, which starts rather from the formal properties extracted as a matter of reason from the relevant notion of the good.³⁴ Indeed in the *NE* we find something that is more like the straight development of a formal rational theory—that is then constrained by its ability to accommodate and make sense of the *endoxa* in the area (cf. *NE* 1.8, etc.; Lawrence 2001, sec. IV). Nonetheless these formal criteria are later re-deployed in the specification of the activity constitutes *eudaimonia*—to reach a result that, as Anaxagoras surmised, the many would find surprising.

But there are more rational principles at work shaping the formal theory. Why, for instance, is Aristotle's search focused primarily on the best activity, and only derivatively on the best life? Here, as I said earlier, he apparently assumes as a truth of reason the following *best activity-to-best life* principle:

- BA If (1) E is the best life-activity (activity of the highest excellence or part of soul), then (2) the ideal situation, the life of absolutely perfect happiness, is one of engaging in E for ever, without any (need for) interruption.³⁵

This is a value transfer principle—transferring value from an activity to a life. The rationale for (BA)—or the principle of inference for concluding (2) from (1)—is the following *no-change thesis*

- NC Any change from E is necessarily a change to an activity that is intrinsically worse or to none, and so a departure

from perfect living, and thus reveals a (metaphysical) badness, or defect, in the agent or their situation.³⁶

Two *nonaggregation theses* are consequent upon (BA):

NA Weak

It is not the case that if there is some best activity E, and there is some other, but less perfectly good activity F, that the life which combines (or has to combine) E and F is better (more ideal) than the life of E alone (i.e., aggregation doesn't add to the goodness of the E life).

NA Strong

If there is some best activity E, and there is some other, but less perfectly good activity F, then the life which combines (or has to combine) E and F is worse (less ideal) than the life of E alone (i.e., aggregation takes away from the goodness of the E life).

The nonaggregation is *not* here to be explained in terms of the greatest good—the best activity—being an *inclusive one*, but in terms of the defectiveness of other goods, other activities, from the ideal perspective. The goods in question are life-activities well done: and *if* one, E, is better than the others, then the greatest good consists in doing it all the time. (If god were not simple but multi-channelled and could engage in different activities in each channel, still the ideal would be to do E and E alone in each). This is not to deny that relative to agents or their situation it may be best for them to do what is from this ideal perspective an “intrinsically worse” activity, or none at all (cf. *Topics* 3.2.118a8-11), but only to assert that, if it is thus best for them, then the need to change to this activity reveals that there is some defect, something less than perfect, in the agent or their situation.³⁷ It would have been better, more ideal, had the situation not arisen and the perfect activity not have to have been interrupted. And to ensure this, it would have to be such that it was not even susceptible to interruption, and thus avoid even the possibility of accident.

There are other consequences too. First two self-sufficiency theses:

- SS1 If there is some best activity E, then by NA Strong it suffices by itself to make life lacking in nothing—in the sense there is nothing more one would ideally have reason to want: for anything else one has to do will *take away* from one's bliss—and thus evince a defect in oneself or one's situation (cf. 1.7.1097b6-15).

- SS2 If there is some best activity E, then it will itself be self-sufficient in not depending on other activities—for these would require change away from E; nor on opportunities or resources, for these might fail and force a change away from E (cf. 10.7.1177a27-b1, 10.8.1178a23-b7).

Furthermore (BA) implies a no-value-in-variety thesis:

- NVV There is no (absolute) value in variety; any value attaching to variety must be only in some qualified way (i.e., with respect to some type of organism, or individual or set of circumstances); and the qualification reveals some defect, something less than perfect, about the agent or their situation (cf. 7.14.1154b20-31).

These theses make clear what has to be done: we must determine the perfect life-activity—for the perfect substance will simply be one that engages in that all the time. They also guide our construction, or discovery, of this perfect life-activity and its agent. The perfect substance will have to be such that its nature and its circumstances allow it, indeed make it best for it, to engage in the best life-activity, E, all the time. In its case, the “however circumstanced ideal” collapses into “the ideally circumstanced ideal”; that is, no circumstances arise, or rather can arise, for it which are nonideal ones, ones in which it would no longer be best to do the best activity.

How might this result be secured? One way would be to give the perfect substance omnipotence, power to secure the relevantly perfect circumstances, and to render its purposes unfrustratable; but another, which avoids problems of efficient causation on the part of such would-be objects as Gods or Minds when these are supposed immaterial, is to make the perfect substance and its life-activity *immune* to any possible affecting circumstance or condition. The former is an absolute *practical* freedom—the power to do whatever one wants; the latter is an absolute *metaphysical* freedom—stemming from something whose very nature and situation already frees it from any need to do anything but the single best activity.³⁸ The absence of potency is here a mark of perfection, its presence of defect: the perfect substance shouldn’t need to have to do anything in order to achieve the best activity—it should simply engage in it (*De Caelo* 2.12.292a22-3).

What would such an agent, and its activity and situation, have to be like to meet these desiderata? (A) The nature of the perfect substance will be determined by that of the perfect activity—for the latter will constitute the essence of the former. But, as regards the perfect substance, it seems obvious that to secure this immunity to any change away from the best activity it must be immortal—free from that cessation of all activity

brought about by going out of existence; moreover it must be a living thing (cf. *Meta.* L.7.1072b26-30), free from any other needs and interests whose satisfaction would require its engaging in activities other than the best, or in recuperating. Thus it needs to have no other faculties for other life-activities: it would be a living thing whose essence is constituted simply by one life-activity—the very best one: suffering neither tiredness nor distraction of other calls. So it would be immaterial, or at least without a physical body: for bodies tire and have multifarious needs and are generally the sort of thing that squash or (lest one be tempted by the idea of a spherical rubber god) melt. Moreover besides being immortal and immaterial, it will need to be entirely sufficient unto itself and quite immune to any possible circumstance or condition. That is, it will not depend at all on the world, whether to stand on or to eat, to perceive or even to think about.³⁹ (B) As regards the perfect life-activity, this must be supremely good or valuable and also the most enjoyable, both in terms of the purity and the durability of the pleasure it affords—it must never become tedious and boring; nor must it be an exhausting activity, as any body-involving activity would eventually be.⁴⁰ Then again this activity too in its very nature must be free from the necessity of change or cessation—thus it must not be a *process* (*kinesis*), something which, in its very nature, marches to an end, and which in that case would anyway not be as good as the end to which it was directed (*NE* 1.1.1094a5-6). So the perfect life-activity must be an activity in the strict sense, something that is not proceeding to a completion, but already carries its completion in it at each moment—and so is something in its very nature continuable ad infinitum. It has its end *in itself* and not external to itself like a process (it is *autoteles*: cf. *Pol.* 7.3.1325b20). The activity then is a final good, one sought *for itself* and not for some other good to which it is an instrumental means; and in fact it can only ever be sought for itself alone. Again the perfect activity, like the perfect substance, must be self-sufficient in a very strong sense that renders it immune to worldly happenstance: it must not essentially involve the body, as, for example, running does, for a body, besides tiring, can break down, be impaired or damaged; it must not essentially require external resources of any kind (in the way that an act of generosity might require something to be generous with); nor must it be essentially dependent on the occurrence of suitable situations, or on suitable objects, unless these are of a sort that can in no way fail it. Activities that are dependent in these ways are *vulnerable* to cessation and impairment: in particular they may be *thrust back into mere potentiality*—as a human painter may be forced back from the activity of painting a wall into being a merely potential painter through a broken arm, or lack of paint, or lack of any further wall needing to be painted—

and, in the case of the perfect activity, this would be a change to a worse life-activity, or to none.⁴¹ It seems then we must take the perfect life-activity, like the perfect substance, to be invulnerable to the world, and entirely sufficient unto itself. Given this self-sufficiency and world-independence, it is then in a certain sense an action *internal* to the perfect substance, one not directed at others, nor in fact in any way directed out into the world (cf. *Pol.* 7.3.1325b17ff.).

But this immunity and invulnerability could hardly, it might seem, be mere happenstance—a fortuitous accident. The perfect activity would surely have to be such that it *could not* be pushed back into mere potency, but is rather *essentially* active (cf. *De An.* 3.5.430a17-18; *Meta.* L.7.1072a25-6, b7-8, 27-8, L9.1074b28ff.). As such it might be destructible but not drivable into potentiality. Moreover such a conception of the perfect activity can now seem to undermine any need to, and any possibility of, distinguishing between it and the perfect substance: the move seems to eliminate the need for a separate subject of the activity. One might seem to have needed *that* only for the *potentiality* of engaging in the perfect activity to inhere in: if it is an essentially active activity then nothing *can* engage in it, and now nothing seems needed, or possible, for the essentially active activity to be possessed by (or to inhere in). The perfect substance can, or must, now be identified with the perfect activity—as it were sucked up into it. So the activity is indeed not dependent on any other thing than itself, not even on a subject that is other than itself. And thus what looks like a category mistake, a Doing's being treated as a Substantial Being, transmogrifies into a metaphysical insight. (As one might think of the sun as nothing more than the activity of light.)

Now part of the value of an activity is for Aristotle a matter of the activity's object—he appears to hold some such thesis as the following:

- BO *Best Object*: one activity is better in kind than another in virtue of its object being better in kind, and an activity is better than another activity of the same kind, if it has a better object of the kind in question.⁴²

If so, the perfect activity will have the best or perfect object as its object. But of course we are precisely delineating the best thing—the best thing in the best category (substance). And so the perfect activity will have itself as object (*Meta.* L.7.1072b18-24; 9.1074b33-5; 1075a1-5; cf. Clark 1975, 178ff). And in a peculiarly intimate way: the activity carries its own object with it—the object cannot fail to appear and force the activity back into potency. The object too we may think of as sucked up into the activity—so inseparable is it. A light may fail to illuminate

objects in a room, because such objects may fail—the room may be empty; but the light cannot, one may think, fail to illuminate itself—it has itself as a kind of primary and undetachable object. It could be destroyed (the light extinguished) but not drivable into potentiality through loss of object to illuminate: for in being it has itself.

Such—if somewhat crudely drawn—is the formal specification of the perfect activity generated by this metaphysical project. Aristotle's material theory can be presented in three steps. (S1) First he holds the best life-activity must be some kind of reason-involving one as against any of the other life-activities—and it is this that constitutes our humanity (1.7.), thus differentiating us from other sublunary organisms, and that makes us best of animals (6.7). (S2) But, secondly, it is not just any reason-involving activity: he draws, as we have seen, a strong contrast between human practical thought and theoretical thought—as evinced in the subjects of natural science, mathematics and first philosophy or theology (e.g., 6.1.1139a3-15; *Meta.* E.1.; *De An.* 2.2., 2.3., and 3.10, etc). There is here a second focality, the activities of practical reason being for the sake of those of theoretical reason, just as the other life-activities were for the sake of reason-involving ones (6.13. 1145a6-11; *Pol.* 7.14.1333a16-30). Moreover theoretical intellect, *nous*, is a very special part of soul. It has no bodily organ, and its activity is not one that is essentially en-mattered (synthetic), that is, not an activity the account of whose nature reveals it to be the actualization of some bodily part. And the objects of this activity are ones whose common thread is that, in contrast to practical matters, they concern things whose starting points cannot be otherwise (they are necessary and eternal) and that are always one and the same (for all). These are universals that “are in a sense in the soul” and not, as with practical thought, particulars outside the soul. Hence it is in one's power to “think” them, and to think them whenever one wants.⁴³ They are thus to that extent candidates for being unfailing objects—though one might suppose them still vulnerable, for example, to forgetfulness, temporary or entire, on the agent's part. (S3) But, thirdly, there is yet another focality or at least primacy *within* the theoretical, in accord with the value of their objects, with theology taking pride of place (*Meta.* E.1.1026a18-23), and perhaps even a further one within this, to the most perfect version of this activity—thinking thinking thinking (*Meta.* L.9.1074b33-5).

What can we make of this? Aristotle allows that the best thinking, or contemplating, we can achieve may only be akin to that which the perfect substance achieves, or is (if it exists). But it looks like some attempt to capture a notion of self-consciousness, only at the limiting case where the “self” of which the consciousness is conscious is simply that conscious-

ness itself and so is something that is, in its single act, *entirely* transparent to itself as nothing involving matter could be. It is as a self-illuminating light, in which its being and understanding are no longer to be differentiated:⁴⁴ it is wholly and perfectly present to itself at each moment.

So Aristotle specifies the absolutely unconditional good in the category of substance as god, which he perhaps identifies with intellect.⁴⁵ This in turn is identical with its activity, contemplation (*theoria*). And the life consisting entirely and solely of this activity for ever and ever is perfect happiness (*teleia eudaimonia*), the absolutely unqualified good life. This is god: and it is indeed a distinctly metaphysical, “transcendental,” life-activity—not involving change or matter (or body), and so not to be studied by the *phusikos*, the natural scientist (*De An.* 1.1.403a25-8; *Meta.* E.1.1025b34-26a6, 27-32, L.1.1069a36-b2).⁴⁶ And it is that that sets the standard for success in human, as in all, life.

7. Aristotle and the Benchmark Theory

If this is Aristotle’s specificatory theory, what of his benchmark theory? This apparently consists in a *theory of focal value* (comparable to the theory of focal being). Everything else so far as it is good is so by being related in some way or other, but not necessarily the same way, to the one absolutely unconditionally good thing (*anapherein pros hen*), the thing that is prized, not merely praised (*NE* 1.12). Formally this good is *eudaimonia*. As Aristotle says in *NE* 1.12:

But it is clear to us from what has been said that happiness is among things prized and perfect. And it seems to be so also on account of being a first principle (*arche*): for it is for the sake of this that we all do everything else we do, and we posit the first principle and the be-cause [explanation] of good things to be something prized and divine. (1101b35-1102a3, cf. b27-31)

It is then *eudaimonia* that, for Aristotle, plays the role of Plato’s Form of the Good—in being the “*arche kai aitia*” of other good things. And this would seem an improvement in metaphysical robustness: in place of something metaphysically obscure—empty language—we have something of a recognized status, a life-activity (or a substance).

Materially, it is Aristotle’s claim that this unqualified success or happiness is contemplation—that it is contemplation that alone is prized itself for itself (*haute kath’hauten timia*: *NE* 10.8.1178b31). And so in the continuation of the *Metaphysics* passage quoted earlier, where Aristotle explains the world’s having the good in it as being also in its order, we find him referring everything to god\contemplation (*Meta.* L.10.1075a16ff):

And all things are drawn up together in a sense (*pos*), but not in the same way—both things of the sea and the air and the earth; and they are not so related that there is nothing for the one in relation to the other, but there is something. For indeed *everything is drawn up together in-relation-to one thing* (*pros hen*), but just as in a house it is least possible for the free people to do any chance thing, but [for them] everything, or most things, are drawn up, while for the slaves and the wild animals the contribution to the common is small, and the chance great: for the nature of each of them is a principle of this sort.

The world is ordered round one thing—the best thing, its ‘general’; not all in the same way, some reflect closer ties to it—evince more of its nature—others less, and appear more random (cf. *De Caelo* 1.9.279a28-30).⁴⁷

The way in which human beings are related to the good is such that they, and they alone of sublunary living things, have a share in happiness. They alone have a share in the divine. We can talk of other things living well or badly, but not as living happy lives.⁴⁸ In *NE* 10.8. Aristotle specifies the relation in the case of humans in terms of kinship (*suggenes*: 1179a23; 26) and similarity (*homoioma*: 10.8. 1178b27). Other animals do not engage in any activity that is akin to—or of the same kind as—god’s. It is because humans, unlike mere beasts, share in divine contemplative activity—have a share in what the *De Anima* says is like (*eoike*) a different kind (*genos*) of soul (2.2.413b24-28, cf. 2.3.415a11-12)—that they too have a share in happiness.⁴⁹

So then the life of perfect *eudaimonia*—happiness or success absolutely unqualified—would be one consisting of the best activity, contemplation, forever, without any need for, or possibility of, interruption. This is achieved by god—indeed it *is* god. And it sets the standards for humans: for our best possible life will be one whose circumstances allow us to approximate or resemble god’s condition so far as we humanly can, given the inevitable demands of our physical, emotional, and social natures. Any need to change away from this activity reflects defects in ourselves or our conditions by the standard of the divine.

8. Conclusion

I hope to have made some progress in clarifying Aristotle’s project in the *NE*, and in characterizing a certain approach that, although historically influential, is not altogether congenial to the modern mind. The view is sublime. But in a way everything that is *really* difficult remains—the nature, and intelligibility, of “contemplation”; the contrast Aristotle draws between practical and theoretical reason, and the priority he gives the latter; the viability and proper level of application, if any, of a formal account of the good, or of perfection; the priority

he gives to life-activity over life-form (influenced presumably the hierarchical nature of basic types of life-activity). The view, while sublime, is, I fear, sublime nonsense. We face a double task: to uncover the wrong turning—which I suspect to lie in certain apparent principles of reason, grammatical remarks taken metaphysically—and to show that Aristotle's project, pruned of metaphysical sublimity, survives as a viable and powerful one.

Notes

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¹ Certainly in “us” and “our environment” as particular individuals; whether, and in what sense(s), also in “us” as a particular species, i.e., in our human nature, will become an issue.

² One immediately wants to ask about those whose greatest potential seems realized precisely in defective circumstances—men and women of action and crisis, *humans for hard times*, whose talents lie fallow in peace and prosperity, where they may go to seed: a difficult topic.

³ This is Aristotle's distinction of *haplos/pos*. It turns on the effect of, or need for, qualifying clauses (things added “*kata prosthesis*”). For example, in *NE* 7.2 Aristotle asks “who is the *akrates haplos*?” His point is that sometimes we call someone “akratic” without adding any qualifying phrase, such as “with respect to anger.” When we do this, whom do we mean? What are the truth conditions for someone being “akratic” *sans phrase*? Are they so by being akratic about everything, or only about some specific area, say, the physical appetites? (Cf. also Hintikka 1972, 21–5).

⁴ “Human nature is not self-sufficient with regard to contemplating, but there is need also for the body to be healthy, and for nourishment and other care to be on hand” (*NE* 1178b33–5, cf. 1177a27–29; 1177b26ff). The Human needs various forms of social intercourse, being by nature a *politikon zoon*, a social animal. See *NE* 1178b5–8; cf. 1.7.1097b8–11; *Pol.* 1.2.1253a2–3, and generally 1252b27–53a29: a life outside society is either subhuman or super-human (“*kreitton e anthrōpos*” a4)—that of a dumb beast or a god (a29). A human outside society would be human only homonymously, as an amputated, or stone, hand is a hand (a18–25). If so, exclusive and uninterrupted contemplation is not humanly possible. Inevitably situations will arise that demand ethical and political activity. But a life whose circumstances demand entire lifetime immersion in such activity is, while successful and worth the living, not as ideal as one whose circumstances leave time *free* for contemplation—and ideally as much as possible within the unavoidable demands of the human situation even at its most fortunate.

⁵ Cf. *Rep.* I 340D–E. A failure needs a particular explanation in a

way success does not: there is room for questions “why/where did you go wrong?” where there is not room for “why/where did you go right?” We do not explain an individual’s getting a particular sum right, other than by saying they know how to add (setting aside “by accident”); but each failure has its individual explanation, although there are types of human error (and there are, I suspect, curious parasitic norms even here, as there are, relatedly, norms in educational progression and development).

⁶ Two problems are standardly raised for Utopianism.

(1) First, supposedly it seeks a once and for all solution to the problem of human good or happiness—a fixed or static solution. But this is completely a-historical. It takes no account of the essentially dynamic nature of (human) life, in which the problem must ever be faced anew. And it presupposes an incoherent compatibility, or harmony, of human goods and ideals (cf. Berlin 1969, 188; 1978/1990, 20–2, 30; 1988/1990, 5–14).

(2) Second, the implementation of the Utopian end is thought to justify all sorts of outrages—worries of ‘the end justifies the means’ sort (cf. Berlin 1988/1990, 15–16).

The second criticism seems misplaced. (a) It is a version of the classic complaint against utilitarianism, viz. that it cannot cope with justice. But it need be no part of Utopianism that the end can be realized by any and every means—that its pursuit is not constrained by other values. That problem is one that attaches to value monism, not necessarily activity monism: for the latter is compatible with value pluralism, and the ordinary problem of finding the correct way through competing, or constraining, values—the wise course. (b) The fact that Utopianism can be a dangerous form of thought—Berlin’s worries may be historically *à propos*—in that even a sensible one can be misunderstood and tempt people into impermissible outrages even for the best of ends—only shows that people are liable to a certain kind of error in this area, not that there is something inevitably wrong with this kind of thinking.

The first criticism needs careful consideration. It is not obvious that it makes sense to talk of “human nature changing.” That aside, the more formal a specification of the Utopian life, the more “static and a-historical” it can afford to be; the more concrete it is, the more there is a real danger of being implausibly rigid and a-historical. (There are different Utopian questions here. Is one searching for a very general specification, or for one attuned to the historical moment? And there are difficult problems over, for example, when to count the absence of some invention or knowledge a defect in the life of a previous generation, etc., or over what to count as a full natural lifetime.)

⁷ This sort of worry is often aired in connection with the possible damage to social and emotional life in children subjected to extremely selective education, be it of tennis or of mathematics, or the rigorous rationalism of which J. S. Mill complained in his *Autobiography*.

⁸ Where we ought to change, we can be accused of according an activity, or way of going on, a value beyond its worth—of being staid, conventional, unadventurous, stick-in-the-muds, hidebound, obsessed. Where we ought to persist, we can be accused of inconstancy and light-mindedness, of being distractable and superficial, of failing to take some activity with the seriousness it deserves—butterflies. So either way we can make mistakes.

⁹ Cf. *Pol.* 7.14.1333a16-30. There are other—perhaps more plausible—fault-lines that Aristotle at times draws, e.g., between *necessary* deployments of virtue—to secure goods or ameliorate defects—and *fine*, or good-enjoying, ones.

¹⁰ Aristotle seems also to fall victim to that prejudice of his times that tends to view the arts as merely productive. Actually this can be exaggerated. Aristotle views listening to music as an activity that is a prototype for, and propaedeutic for, contemplation (*Pol.* 8.3.1338a9-37, cf. 8.5.1339a25-6, b10ff), and allows the possibility of other such activities (cf. *Pol.* 8.3.1338a32-4, 1338b1-2).

¹¹ Marx, *Capital* Vol. 3: “Beyond it [sc. the realm of necessity] begins that development of human energy which is an end in itself, the true realm of freedom, which, however, can blossom forth only with the realm of necessity as its basis. The shortening of the working day is its basic prerequisite.”

¹² So, for Aristotle, there is no single science that human life, as such, falls under—or perhaps we should rather say there is no single thing, human life, as such to account for.

¹³ The divine nature of contemplation is suggested by its surface etymology, *the-oria*, “god-seeing”—which at the same time suggests both that it is the activity of god and that it has god as its object.

¹⁴ Aristotle is emphatic that the search is for something humanly achievable, for human good, or human happiness (e.g., *NE* 1.2.1094b7, 1.4.1095a15-17, 1.7.1098a16, 1.13.1102a13-15; *EE* 1.7.1217a21-26; cf. *MM* 1.1.1182b3-5, etc.).

¹⁵ Aristotle again has an eye for the (surface) etymology. He takes it that *eu-daimonia* can only be achieved by something with at least something divine (*-daimon*) in them. Aristotle believes humans have this—for they have *nous*—whereas the lower animals do not, and so lacking a direct share in the divine have no actual share in *eudaimonia* (cf. *EE* 1.7.1217a24-9; *NE* 1.8.1099b32ff, and 10.8.1178b24-31; cf. *De Caelo* 2.12, discussed later).

¹⁶ To increase unnecessarily the risks to which one is subject may also count as a defect—not simply because it may create undue tension and anxiety (for it may not), but because it may be irresponsible both to self and others. What constitutes unnecessary risk at any point is tricky to determine (compare: motorcycling without a crash helmet; mountaineering; living in an earthquake zone). There is also a need in life for some risk—some adventure and danger. Both security and adventure can be well and badly handled.

¹⁷ This starts simply by requiring us to look at the kind of questions we ask about a thing’s final value, and the things we say in reply. Something’s final value lies in its surround, its place in human life—i.e., adverting to facts about a thing’s role and place in our life isn’t *ipso facto* to make it instrumental. So with dancing, one might describe its many different forms and traditions and the value it has in the context of a creature that is physical and enjoys the exuberance of its physicality, and its susceptibility to rhythm, or the elegance and finesse of its physical control, its role in the development of social and emotional relations.

I call such a description the “big story.” It is always open to someone to be puzzled by such an account, and then one can try saying more, giving a further description addressed to the point they are puzzled by. Cf. the anti-foundationalist lesson of Wittgenstein

1953, 87.

¹⁸ Cf. NE 6.7.1141a22-25, 31-33. Their good is determined by their being good members of their species. And just as an individual needs a species so a species needs a world, an environment.

¹⁹ Cf. Darwin's strictures against the use of "higher" and "lower" in describing organisms (Gould, *Ever since Darwin*, 36, quoted in Kraut 1989, 354 fn. 35).

²⁰ Nor is it to say that we couldn't come across another species that we held to be intellectually or morally superior—although many similarities would have to be in place for us to do so. And even so it wouldn't mean "the world" was better off having them rather than us nor that they "deserve" to stay in the world rather than us (in such a sense the same is true between individual humans—and indeed in our example, if the "many similarities" are in place, they precisely undermine the relevant distance of "them" from "us").

²¹ There is also our natural penchant for metaphysics—the hard to repress thought that, in some vague way, surely things could have been better: couldn't we have evolved in a way that naturally let us live for 150 years? 200? 2000? a million?—a thought that, as one stretches it out, proves ever more fugitive, requiring one, in such 'Tithonian' reflection, to change more and more of the ordinary facts of human life, and so lose contact with what one what had originally envisaged. (We tend not to see the "fiction" in science fiction.)

²² Existence, or necessary existence, may be taken as a perfection, and it has, notoriously, been tempting to infer from that to actual existence. But in order for the perfect substance to function as a yardstick, there may seem no need for an antecedent commitment to its *existence* (i.e., part b may not be needed). Conversely, it is tempting suitably to re-configure or reconceptualize what it is for it to "exist." Thus in conceiving the perfections of substance, one might be thought to be delineating the ultimate principle, or essence, of Reason—describing its regulative function over the being and intelligibility of the cosmos, and there is not more to its existence. One could talk here of being and essence being one, or distinguish "formal existence" from "material existence," and suppose that with some things—ones essentially immaterial—their being is simply a matter of formal existence. Matters for consideration elsewhere.

²³ Insofar as IP appears to put the unconditional good *outside* the world, it may seem mysterious how other things can metaphysically depend on it or be explained by it, or what the kind of explanation at issue is: cf. Aristotle's strictures over the Platonic "partaking" relation.

²⁴ Of course the Human can be a bad choice *relative to some task*: "you should have used a computer." Nor do I mean to imply that there cannot be defective conditions in the human condition at large—as would be the case if we so pollute our world that we are reduced to gasping our way round like fish out of water.

²⁵ It is noticeable that the notion of species tends to lose its importance. The ideal substance tends to be viewed as an individual rather than a species; and what are measured by it can seem primarily to be individuals—the various species to which they belong being viewed as forms of limitation. I.e. being a member of a species, and confined by the limits of such, can appear as just another sort of defect an individual can suffer from. Or perhaps it is not that the perfect substance is a pure individual rather than the singular

member of a singular species, but that the distinction has no application here; relatedly the grammar of “form” as “form of” here changes into pure “form” (cf. fn. 44).

²⁶ The nonhuman objects of these activities endow them with value. (This becomes particularly forceful when the nature of contemplation as a metaphysical activity becomes clear: it is an activity quite independent of all other aspects of human life, quite apart from them. It has itself as primary object—something not specifically human—and though in a sense it is what is most of all what it is to be a human (NE 10.7.1178a2-7), it is divine as against merely human (cf. NE 10.7.1177b26-31, 1178a9-10; b5-7).

²⁷ In this passage, Aristotle is discussing whether the young (citizens) should learn to play musical instruments themselves or simply to enjoy the playing of others and remarks: “It is possible to consider the assumption/conception (*hupolepsis*) which we have about the gods: for the poets do not have Zeus himself singing and playing the lyre.” *Pol.* 1.2.1253a24-27 is another example.

²⁸ Pace Kraut (1989, 39–41). This seems not a metaphysical argument, but simply one from popular conception. Notice the occurrence of “we assume/conceive” in 1178b9 and 18 (*hupolambanein*), as in the *Pol.* 8.5. passage. The “we” is I think the ordinary “us” and not the philosophical “us.”

²⁹ Thus Jaeger (1923/1948) Ch III-IV, IX (for references see White 1981, 227, note 7); cf. Nussbaum 1986, 373–7, esp. 377. For further references see Roche 1988, 192, esp. notes 31 and 32.

³⁰ Cf. e.g., 1.13. 1102a23-28, 10.8.1178a22-3. Thus someone who wants to view Aristotle as a systematic thinker, and not appeal to developmental hypotheses, may urge that a systematic thinker can put forward part of his system in such a way as to be acceptable even to those who would not buy into other parts.

³¹ The passage is tricky. It seems to intertwine two (or more) lines of argument:

- L1: *phronesis* is species specific; so if one *phronesis* is better than others, it would have to be the *phronesis* of the better species or better being. If human *phronesis* were the best kind of knowledge or understanding, then the human would have to be the best thing in the cosmos. But this is not the case.
- L2: a contrast between *phronesis* which is species specific and theoretical wisdom (*sophia*) which studies what is in each case the same (e.g., the white and straight): so it is one where *phronesis* is many. It also studies what is by its nature most valuable—the most conspicuous things from which the cosmos is composed (presumably the heavens).

The former would suggest that the most valuable knowledge is practical wisdom in the case of the most valuable being; the latter that it is not practical wisdom at all. Perhaps Aristotle takes himself to be arguing from two directions: (i) if human *phronesis* is the best knowledge, then the human must be the best thing—which is not the case; (ii) in any case there is a better candidate for top knowledge—it is species invariant, and studies the best things.

³² Cf. Kahn 1985, 192ff, and *passim*.

³³ (a) One species rather than another? Or one individual rather than another, within a species? The natural reading is, I think, the former; this is supported by the *De Caelo* 2.12. passage discussed above.

(b) Woods objects:

... if, as implied here, human beings are described as happy or unhappy on the strength of their possession of human goods it is not clear why a horse should not be so called, by analogy, on the strength of its possession of the appropriate equine goods. (65)

This is a thought from a species-contextual perspective. Wood's puzzlement just shows it is not that perspective we have here. Rather it is implied that we have our share in the predicate "*eudaimon*" because we actually share in something divine—can engage in some strictly *eu-daimonic* activity, in line with the parallel remark in *NE* 10.8.1178b24-28 (cf. 10.6.init); cf. also *NE* 1.9.1099b32-1100a4. See note 15 above.

³⁴ Much contemporaneous work had evidently been done on what we can call *the formal theory of the good*—its formal criteria and marks (cf. 1.7.1097a24-b21, 1.12, 10.2, 10.7.1177a19-b26, and note the final clause "and all the others," 1177b22-3; Plato, *Philebus* 20C-22C). A prime mover in the project seems to have been Eudoxus, in search of arguments to support his case for taking pleasure as *the good*.

³⁵ Compare Plato, *Rep.* 2 380D-381C, 381E, 382E, and *NE* 7.14.1154b20-31. The thesis comes in cosmic, sublunary, and species-relative versions depending on whether "activity of the highest excellence or part of soul" is taken to range over the cosmos (i.e., including god), over sublunary nature, or simply over a particular species.

³⁶ Cf. *Meta.* L.9.1074b25-27; Plato, *Rep.* 2.381B-C. (It is not clear whether the thesis of *NE* 7.14.1154b28-29, from Euripides' *Orestes* 234, is understood this way or not.)

³⁷ Not necessarily an ordinary defect, like a vice, but a metaphysical one. Thus an agent's need for and possession of the ethical virtues is itself—like the need for variety—revelatory of a metaphysical defect (cf. the *De Caelo* passage cited earlier).

³⁸ From this angle, potency is weakness and vulnerability: it reveals that the substance is such that it might need to do something in order to secure the best, or that it might fall into circumstances where it was better to do something other than simply enjoy (being) the very best thing.

³⁹ Nor will it have any need for another of its kind. Indeed properly understood, one suspects, its kind will appear necessarily unique—or talk of kind or species will have no point (cf. fn. 25, 44).

⁴⁰ See *NE* 10.7.1177a19-21, 22-27, and 21-2 for these three criteria. The "purity" of a pleasure I take to be the absence of any pain: cf. 7.12.1152b35-53a2, 7.14.1154b15-17.

⁴¹ Thus the desideratum is to eliminate those things, or conditions, which might lead to the ideal activity's being pushed back into potentiality in any way (whether by a need to give way to some other activity or by the failure of some condition necessary to its exercise) and thus prevent its being continuously actively engaged in.

⁴² "The best activity is that of the best part of soul, and which activity and part are best is determined by the value of its object (on

the cosmic scale).” This principle of value transference is a value version of the *De An.* 2.4.415a16-22 principle and seems the implication of *NE* 6.7.1141a18-b3. (See also 10.4.1174b14-26, b33-1175a3 (the latter makes clear the application to object of thought as well as to that of perception). Cf. perhaps also *EE* 1.5.1216b19-20: “Now it is fine even to know each of the fine things”; and *Meta* E.1.1026a21-23.

⁴³ *NE* 6.1., cf. 6.5.; *NE* 6.7.1141a16-b8; *De An.* 2.5.417b16-28 (with qualifications over the sciences of the perceptibles).

⁴⁴ Two comments. (i) First, it is not simply that what it is for the perfect substance to be consists in its active fully transparent self-understanding. But rather something inexpressible—for in the case of the perfect substance many distinctions seem to lose their sense or application: existence and essence; individual and species; being and understanding and goodness. One might think of these distinctions in terms of dimensions that only *separate out* in imperfect beings, or beings that are contaminated with matter—and so have potentialities and as subjects cannot be entirely or perfectly self-transparent. The distinctions themselves are so to speak modes of imperfection—drawn by imperfect beings for imperfect beings.

(ii) Second, it may be held that the self in any self-consciousness is always ultimately only that consciousness itself, even for humans—it is just that we have a weaker, less distinct, version of it than god—our light-bulbs are not of divine wattage (or we have god’s imperfectly). Bound up in matter our self-consciousness is perhaps muddled by the other things we mistakenly take ourselves to be, or unfortunately are.

⁴⁵ Cf. *NE* 1.6.1096a23f; *Meta*. L.7.; *De An.* 3.5. Sometimes Aristotle wavers between the identification of god with *nous* and the possibility that god might be greater than *nous* (*Peri Euches* frg.1. Ross; *EE* 1248a27ff). Clark (1975, 174–5), following Plotinus, regards this wavering over the identification as an early view. But, quite apart, from the implicit controversial early dating of the *EE*, the claim is under argued.

⁴⁶ Moreover it is an internal activity: cf. *Pol.* 7.3.1325b16-30—and not even one necessarily between parts (b23-27): for god is partless, *ameres* (*Meta*. L.7.1073a6-7, cf. L.9.1075a5-10).

⁴⁷ Thus one might think of plants. These too are part of the order: they strive in their life-activities to mimic the unconditionally best thing so far as they can (cf. *De An.* 2.4.415a26-b7).

⁴⁸ Cf. the passage quoted earlier from *EE* 1.7.1217a26-29 and the other references.

⁴⁹ But can’t a human life that is entirely taken up with ethical and political activity also be a *eudaimon* one, albeit to a secondary degree? Yes, but the worth and worthwhileness of such activity is due in part to its relation to the possibility of contemplation and full happiness: that in acting ethically one may be freeing up time for contemplation for oneself and/or others (cf. p. 7). Human beings are worth taking very seriously because of their divine potential.

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